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Travel Radio Australia and we're very honoured to welcome Aaron Fessler from TripWorks.com. Aaron, welcome to the program. Thank you, thank you so much Jeff, nice to chat with you today. Now tell us about TripWorks and how you came to start the company.

It's a great company and it really helps organizers of events and that sort of thing around the world and tour guides, yes? Well yes, so I've spent most of my career at the intersection of technology and travel or tourism and after a few successful technology companies, I decided to try something a bit different and share my passion of cars or automobiles with others. And so, long story short, I ended up acquiring about 100 acres on the strip in Las Vegas and developing a significant tourist attraction called Speed Vegas. And if you make your way to Las Vegas and you've ever wondered what it's like to experience the thrill of driving a Ferrari or a Lamborghini or something like that, that's the place to do it.

So we moved about a half a million cubic yards of dirt and built a mile and a half high-speed racetrack and off we went. And along the way, I discovered what a lot of tour operators found, that the needs to build and scale and grow an attraction of that scale are pretty unique. And at the time, the market really didn't offer the kinds of things that we felt we needed to build and grow and scale that business.

And so ultimately, after I exited that business, I took everything we learned and that became TripWorks. So it's really designed to help large tourist attractions build, grow and scale a business. It is wonderful.

I think I saw it, I was in Vegas a year or two ago and I was aware of SpeedWorks because it's still going, right? Oh, it sure is. Yes, it's enormous. About a quarter of a million people per year go through that attraction, just a few miles south of the center of Las Vegas.

You really can't miss it. But very, very popular and great attraction. If you make your way back, feel free to call me and I'll show you where my kids' names are etched in the cement during construction.

But it's a place that's near and dear to our family. Sounds fantastic. I spent three months in Las Vegas in 1996, trained as a magician there actually with Lance Burton.

So that's my other job, as well as a journalist. So I love Vegas and it's really great. Now, you keep a close eye on the tours and activities world globally.

What's happening in the industry in Australia and the wider region right now? Yeah, it's a great question. And I would say that the market for both technology and travel and tourism has gone through two seismic changes, one in 2020 and then more or more recently. In 2020, of course, we were facing the global effects of the pandemic from COVID.

And that certainly forced a lot of operators to think really hard about their business and how to survive and then ultimately thrive. And then once folks got back on their feet, we're really finding that once again, we're in this unbelievable period of transformation, largely fueled by AI. And so we're, as a provider of technology to growing attractions, often asked to share our perspective on how these two changes and more commonly and more recently, the impact of AI is creating opportunity and challenge for people moving forward.

The good news is that while there's a lot of fear in different pockets of the global economy, I think that I get a lot of comfort from understanding that you and I are fundamentally humans. And what that means is we're going to want to taste and touch and feel and do. That's not going to change.

Our humanity won't go away. And so once you get comfortable with that, I think you realize that there will continue to be a market for travel and tour and attraction operators to continue to thrive and do well, pretty sure about that. And the way we go about doing it is going to change, but our humanity will never go away.

Yes, well, most travelers never think about the technology behind booking a tour. What actually happens behind the scenes when someone books an experience through your company? Yeah, it's a good question. I think that initially, they call it 10 years ago, a lot of operators were moving from pen and paper to digital systems.

That was sort of the original land rush that took place about 10 years ago. That's largely behind us. Maybe not so much in all regions.

It's different in Europe versus North America versus Australia. But by and large, most operators have successfully moved away from pen and paper and adopted systems to help run and scale their business. Where we're at today is that there are two big things that are causing operators to once again have to look at the way that they run a business.

Number one is that the journey that the average buyer takes is significantly different than it was two years ago or five years ago. In the past, they might have relied heavily upon social media, or paid advertising, perhaps word of mouth. And today, it's not that.

It's a piece of it. But by and large, the two largest drivers are either number one, discovery through AI. So ask anyone, you know, younger than our age range, and you're going to see how strongly they rely upon AI systems, chat, GPT, and Gemini, and these sorts of platforms to discover and curate and explore and learn.

It's really, really big. So operators that have figured that out and made sure that they are seen and felt in the right places are doing well. Those that haven't are falling further behind.

And second is distribution. Distribution is a really, really big part of it. So increasingly, you can see that the macro trends, but increasingly operators are selling their attractions on OTAs

globally, whether it's GetYourGuide, or Viator, or Expedia, there's a very, very long tail of distributors that are an increasingly important part of success for any tourist attraction.

So similarly, operators are wrestling with the right mix of OTAs and distribution. The core business, these channels are often expensive, but they're usually really effective, need to play an overall part in the total mix of revenue for any operation. Yeah, and for a family-run tour business listening right now to us across the world, what is your practical advice on getting started with AI? I would say the first is making sure that any booking software or technology stack that you use is really modern and fresh.

And what we're finding is that there are some legacy providers that came to market maybe 10 years ago, did focus on that first rush that I described a few moments ago, that initial movement from pen and paper to software-based systems. And so back then the message was, we'll give you a great calendar, we'll give you some manifests, we'll give you ways to send emails out to your guests. Those are all table stakes, right? At this point, a decade later, that's sort of taken for granted.

So instead, I think most attractions are really wise to look carefully about how well their booking platform is using, making sure that their content is discoverable by AI, and pricing can be found, dynamic or static, great product copy, knowledge basis, but all that kind of information needs to be very, very accessible to AI systems in order for them to be found and discovered. There's certain stripe and codes that can be embedded in your website to allow AI to discover you. ChatGPT, that's very important, isn't it? And it's very important that these companies talk to their webmasters to make sure that's all included.

That's right. It's by far the fastest growing segment where the traffic is shifting away from organic search, paid search, social and OTAs toward AI-discovered content. That's a pretty big global trend right now.

I always ask this, a couple of your favorite experiences, apart from the Speedway in Las Vegas, which is probably your number one, but a couple of your favorite travel experiences you've had recently. We're speaking to Aaron Fessler from TripWorks.com, and it's great to have him on the program. If you could update us on a couple of those, Aaron.

Well, I'm grateful to be in this industry because I do get the chance to get out in the field and see some of my favorite attractions. And I'll give you a few this last year that I've enjoyed. I was in Mexico City and we took a hot air balloon ride over some pyramids at sunrise.

That was a pretty magical experience. I was in Hawaii a few months ago and we took helicopters over some of the volcanoes and explored a few of the islands with my son. That was a pretty magical experience.

There's a lot to like in the Caribbean. There's some discreet whale-watching excursions in San

Diego. I think I've enjoyed that.

I had a lot of opportunity in the last few years to explore Europe and get in touch with my heritage. I'm German, so some of the famous beer gardens, Oktoberfest, those sorts of things. But I do really enjoy getting down in the field and seeing our customers deliver their experience.

And finally, what is next for TripWorks? What are your plans for the future? Yeah, it's really just more of the same. We've really grown extraordinarily. We more than doubled the size of the organization last year and are on track to do something similar.

So it's nice to see what we're doing be validated by our customers. The core areas of focus for us have primarily been around AI enablement. So we've offered capabilities to allow operators to reduce their costs, improve the quality of their product by having AI answer the phones or answer questions after hours, support multi-languages, AI chatbots on the website to make sure that you get really great experiences, enablement to make sure that, again, AI can explore and see inventory and live pricing for operators.

Those are some pretty important applications that are universally, people are universally excited about our platform. And once again, we'd encourage anyone listening to this to head over to TripWorks.com and you have a very expensive website there where people get it, whether you're a tour operator or just anyone interested in travel and the new trends in AI and travel, it would be a great place to start. Well, thank you very much, Aaron.

Aaron Fessler from TripWorks.com. It's been a pleasure having you on the program and thanks very much for your time. Thank you so much. Good to chat with you, Jeff.